CAROS

REAL ESTATE / PRACTICAL GUIDE

The 5-Minute Rule

Speed-to-Lead Playbook for Agents



Illustrative generated scene.

REVENUE FIRST.

You paid for that lead. Give it a next step.

It's 2:14 p.m. You're opening a lockbox. A buyer asks about a listing through a portal.

By the time you finish the showing, the inquiry is buried beneath three calendar alerts.

You're doing the work a good agent does. Your response process needs backup.

None of these are failures of good real estate pros. They're failures of process.

This playbook gives agents, team leaders, and brokerage operators a repeatable first-response system. Use it to assign ownership, send useful replies, book conversations, and keep future buyers from disappearing.

Your operating target: during staffed coverage, make a useful human response attempt within five minutes of an eligible inquiry.

Five minutes is a service target, not a promise of a signed client. An automatic receipt is useful, but it isn't a conversation.

What you'll build

- A coverage map with a named backup.
- A first-response workflow with clear escalation.
- Copy-and-paste scripts for common situations.
- A respectful follow-up sequence.
- A scorecard that connects response to closed business.

Revenue first. Start with the leads already arriving.

Find the gap before buying another lead

Choose your most recent full week. Review every inquiry from portals, website forms, paid campaigns, calls, and referrals.

Keep duplicate inquiries in one contact record. Preserve each inquiry's timestamp and source.

First-response worksheet

Field	Your answer
Week reviewed	_____
Unique new leads	_____
Leads receiving an automated acknowledgment	_____
Leads receiving a human response attempt	_____
Human attempts within five minutes during staffed coverage	_____
Leads still without a named owner	_____
Leads without a recorded next step	_____
Consultations booked / attended	_____ / _____

Record actual elapsed time for every lead, including after-hours arrivals. Report staffed and after-hours performance separately.

Don't let a fast automatic reply hide a slow callback. Track acknowledgment, first human attempt, and two-way conversation separately.

Put dollars beside the gap

Illustrative scenario, not a forecast:

You spend $2,000 and receive 40 unique leads. Your acquisition cost is $2,000 ÷ 40 = $50 per lead.

If ten leads receive no human response attempt, $500 of acquisition spend sits behind those unattended inquiries. That is spending exposure, not proven lost commission.

Now test an outcome scenario. Two additional closings at an assumed $4,000 retained commission each would produce $8,000 before campaign and operating costs. Neither the closings nor that commission amount is guaranteed. Substitute your actual economics.

Give every inquiry an owner

A shared inbox is a location. It still needs a person responsible for what happens next.

Fill in your coverage card

Staffed hours and time zone: _____

Primary agent or intake owner: _____

Backup owner: _____

Escalation contact: _____

After-hours response commitment: _____

Approved booking calendar: _____

Where consent, source, and preferences are recorded: _____

Five-minute workflow

1. Capture. Save the inquiry, source, arrival time, and contact preferences in one record.

2. Check. Look for duplicates, existing representation notes, suppression flags, and an active conversation.

3. Acknowledge. Send an approved receipt through an appropriate, permitted channel. Identify the agent or team clearly.

4. Assign. Notify the primary owner. A notification alone does not count as acceptance.

5. Escalate. As a suggested starting rule, alert the backup if no one accepts within two minutes.

6. Respond. Aim for a useful human attempt before five minutes during staffed coverage.

7. Record. Save the outcome and one dated next action.

Tune the escalation rule to actual capacity. Test it while someone is in a showing, on another call, and unavailable.

For overnight inquiries, acknowledge receipt when appropriate and state an honest callback window. Never advertise round-the-clock human coverage unless you provide it.

First-response scripts that earn a reply

Use these templates only through channels appropriate for the inquiry and the contact's recorded permissions. Replace brackets before use.

Automatic acknowledgment

“Thanks for contacting [Team] about [property or request]. This is an automatic confirmation. [Agent] will follow up [honest time window]. Would you prefer a call or email?”

Human first call

“Hi [Name], this is [Agent] with [Brokerage]. You asked about [property or request]. Is now a good time for two quick questions?”

Then ask:

- “What would you like to know first?”
- “Are you hoping to move soon, or planning ahead?”

If appropriate, clarify whether they already have representation before proposing a consultation.

Voicemail

“Hi [Name], it's [Agent] with [Brokerage], returning your inquiry about [request]. My number is [number]. Let me know a convenient time to connect. Again, [number].”

Permitted text after a missed connection

“Hi [Name], [Agent] at [Brokerage] here, replying to your inquiry about [request]. Is [time A] or [time B] convenient for a short call? Reply STOP to stop texts.”

Use your messaging platform's approved opt-out handling. Don't manually send around a suppression setting.

Availability isn't verified

“I'll confirm the property's current status before discussing a showing. Meanwhile, what timing works for a quick conversation?”

Automation can route a question. It should never invent listing availability, financing terms, or an agent's schedule.

Follow up without turning into background noise

No reply doesn't tell you whether someone is busy, browsing, or no longer interested.

Use this as a starting sequence, not a mandatory number of touches. Adjust to the inquiry, permissions, local requirements, and brokerage policy.

Timing	Purpose	Suggested copy
Initial response	Answer the actual request	“You asked about [request]. Here's what I can confirm: [verified answer]. What would help next?”
Next staffed day	Offer one easy next step	“Would a quick call help, or would you prefer details by email?”
Around day 3	Add something useful	“Here's [relevant, verified resource]. Is your timeline closer to this month or later?”
Around day 7	Ask about future contact	“Should I close the loop, or would occasional updates be useful? You can choose the channel and frequency.”

Stop the sequence when the contact replies, books, declines, opts out, or becomes an active client. The agent then chooses the next step.

“We're probably eighteen months away.”

“That helps. What's driving the timing? If useful, I can send an occasional planning note and reconnect around [agreed month]. What frequency works for you?”

Record the reason, agreed cadence, preferred channel, and next conversation date.

“We already have an agent.”

“Thanks for letting me know. I'll close this inquiry on our side. Wishing you a smooth move.”

Route any representation questions to the responsible professional. Don't let an automated campaign keep pursuing the contact.

Your database shouldn't be a digital graveyard. It shouldn't be a megaphone either.

Book the conversation and protect the handoff

“Call me sometime” creates another task. A confirmed appointment creates a next step.

Booking script

“Would [time A] or [time B] work for a [duration]-minute consultation? We'll cover [purpose]. If neither works, tell me what does.”

Confirmation template

Subject: Your conversation with [Agent]: [date, time, time zone]

“Hi [Name], we're set for [date and time, including time zone]. We'll meet by [phone, video, or location].

We'll discuss [purpose]. You don't need to prepare documents for this first conversation.

Need to change it? [Rescheduling link or reply instructions].

See you then,

[Agent], [Brokerage], [contact details]”

Handoff checklist

[ ] Contact's original question is visible to the agent.

[ ] Source and arrival time remain attached to the record.

[ ] Appointment appears on the correct live calendar.

[ ] Contact preferences and permission records are visible.

[ ] Reminder timing matches the contact's preferences.

[ ] Replies pause unrelated automatic messages.

[ ] A missed appointment creates a human follow-up task.

No-show follow-up

“Hi [Name], we missed each other today. Would you like to reschedule, switch to email, or pause for now?”

Automation where it makes sense, humans where they matter. Questions about representation, contracts, financing, or sensitive circumstances belong with the appropriate professional.

Measure the system, then improve one thing

Review the scorecard weekly. Compare closing results by lead arrival cohort over a realistic transaction window.

Metric	Calculation or definition
Five-minute coverage rate	Eligible staffed-hours leads attempted within five minutes ÷ all eligible staffed-hours leads
Human response time	Arrival to first human attempt; review median and slowest cases
Conversation rate	Leads with a two-way conversation ÷ unique leads
Consultation attendance	Attended consultations ÷ booked consultations
Source acquisition cost	Source spend ÷ unique leads from that source
Cost per closed client	Source spend ÷ closed clients attributed to that source

Define exclusions before reporting. Keep excluded duplicates or spam visible in a separate count. Never drop unanswered leads to improve the response score.

Friday review questions

- Which lead waited longest, and why?
- Which backup failed to receive or accept an alert?
- Which response answered the question most clearly?
- Which source produced conversations that progressed?
- What single change will we test next week?

Research note: A 2011 HBR article reported nearly sevenfold higher lead qualification likelihood for contact attempts within an hour versus even an hour later. It studied multiple industries, not five-minute real estate closings. Source: Oldroyd, McElheran, and Elkington.

Use research as context. Use your own response and closing data to judge your system.

Launch this week. Measure what matters.

Your launch checklist

[ ] Review one week of inquiries.

[ ] Name a primary owner and backup.

[ ] Set staffed hours and an honest after-hours commitment.

[ ] Approve acknowledgment, callback, and booking scripts.

[ ] Confirm permitted channels and suppression handling.

[ ] Test a daytime inquiry, an overnight inquiry, and a duplicate.

[ ] Test a reply, booking, opt-out, and failed delivery.

[ ] Confirm each event stops or changes the correct workflow.

[ ] Schedule the first weekly scorecard review.

Start with one lead source. Expand when capture, routing, handoff, and reporting work consistently.

CAROS supports lead capture, response workflows, consultation booking, nurture, and source attribution. Confirm your lead-source connections and coverage during setup. It works alongside your brokerage and transaction tools. Explore CAROS for Real Estate.

You paid for that lead. Build a process that gives it a clear next step.

First, measure: use the CAROS Speed-to-Lead Calculator to explore response-time scenarios with your own inputs. Treat estimates as planning scenarios, not promised revenue.

Then, find the gaps: get your Free Business Audit through CAROS Resources. Review where response, booking, nurture, and attribution need attention.

Learn. Measure. Audit. Revenue first.